

Asada Salsa

Fried guajillo·pasilla·árbol salsa on a tomatillo-verde base · the only heat at the table

YIELD	ACTIVE	HEAT	KEEPS
~2 cups (480 ml)	~40 min	Hot	1 week, fridge

INGREDIENTS

dried chiles + a canned verde base — weeknight shortcut, upgraded by frying

Guajillo chiles stemmed, seeded — flavor & body	4
Pasilla chiles stemmed, seeded — dark, raisiny	2
Chiles de árbol stemmed, seeds in — the heat engine	12
Chiltepín chiles tiny wild pods — very hot, sharp flash heat	~4 g
White onion thick slabs, to char	½
Garlic skin on, to char	3 cloves
Embasa salsa verde 7 oz / 200 g each can	2 cans
Lard or neutral oil — to fry the salsa	13 g
Knorr caldo de pollo optional — only if it tastes flat	to taste

METHOD

toast · soak · char · blend · fry · balance

- 1

Toast the chiles. Fire the Ooni. Toast guajillo + pasilla flat at the **cooler mouth/edge** — not the screaming center, they scorch — **30–45 sec/side** until they puff, darken, and smell nutty; pull the instant they smell toasty (**guajillo turns acrid fast**). Toast the árbol + chiltepín briefly; they're thin/tiny and scorch first. No Ooni? Comal/cast iron over medium (**~350–400°F**). Have hot water ready.
- 2

Soak. Push all toasted chiles under the hot water; soak **15–20 min** until fully pliable. **SAVE the soaking water** — it's the salsa's liquid and flavor.
- 3

Char the aromatics — on the Ooni. Char onion slabs and skin-on garlic **near the center, hard** — blistered, blackened, soft inside. That live-fire char is the salsa's **signature**; cast iron or an oven can't match it. Peel the garlic.
- 4

Blend. Drained chiles, charred onion, peeled garlic, and **both cans of Embasa** into a blender. Add a splash of reserved soaking water to get it moving. Blend smooth — start thick, you can always loosen. Aim for a sauce that **coats a spoon**.
- 5

Fry it — don't skip. Heat the lard until shimmering (**~325–350°F**). Pour in the salsa (it'll spit — stand back) and fry, stirring, **5–8 min** until it darkens, thickens, and the raw chile edge cooks off. **Single biggest upgrade**; it also fixes the thin volume of canned base.
- 6

Cool, then balance. Off heat, rest **10 min** — flavors are muddy while screaming hot and resolve as they settle. **No salt, no lime by design.** If it tastes flat, stir in a pinch of Knorr caldo de pollo — nothing more.

Heat dial — built hot. 12 árbol + chiltepín is genuinely hot — it still bites once built into the taco (the árbol lingers, the chiltepín flashes) — and it's the **only heat at the table** (the picada marinade is heat-free by design). **Push hotter:** bloom extra árbol/chiltepín whole in the lard 30–45 sec until the oil reddens, *before* the salsa goes in. Milder? Drop to **6 árbol / 2 g chiltepín**. • **No salt, no lime — on purpose.** Embasa is salt-forward and frying concentrates it; the tomatillo base is already tart. **Fresh lime + flaky salt finish the meat at the plate** — don't double up. • **Texture:** keep it **spoonable, not paste** — it has to cling to the crispy diced picada edges; loosen with soaking water if it tightens. • **Make-ahead:** improves overnight as the fried chile rounds out. No cumin/oregano — the meat carries those.